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THUNDERHACKS 2026

Official Hackathon Game Jam Problem Statement & Challenge Brief

★ **GAME JAM TRACK CHALLENGE** ★ | Prize Reward: **$500 CAD**

Sponsored by Algoma University, Faculty of Computer Science and Technology.

Algoma Game Jam

Game Jam Theme: Four Seasons

BACKGROUND & CONTEXT

A game jam asks a team to design and build a playable game in a short, fixed amount of time, around a shared theme. The time limit forces small scope and quick decisions. The theme gives every team the same starting point and leaves the direction open.

The Algoma Game Jam runs as its own track inside ThunderHacks this year, across the Brampton and Sault Ste. Marie campuses. Teams work in the same space and on the same schedule as the other tracks, and present to the judges in the same session.

THE CORE PROBLEM

> *Design and build an original, playable game on the theme Four Seasons. The theme must shape how the game plays. A game that only uses the seasons as a background does not meet the challenge.*

Teams are free to interpret the theme. Spring, summer, fall, and winter can stand for weather, time passing, growth and decay, cycles, change, scarcity and plenty, or anything else a team can justify. Any genre and any engine or framework is allowed.

SOLUTION REQUIREMENTS

Competing teams must build a game that covers all four of the following.

01 A Playable Game Loop

The game has a clear goal, a way to win, lose, or score, and can be played from start to finish.

02 Theme in the Mechanics

The seasons change the rules, the challenge, or the player's choices, and not only the visuals.

03 Consistent Art & Audio

Visuals and sound follow one style and support the theme. Simple and consistent is stronger than detailed and mixed.

04 A Build That Runs On Site

Judges can play the game at the event without the team stepping in to fix or explain it.

BONUS CONSIDERATIONS

Teams may receive additional consideration for incorporating one or more of the following:

1. All four seasons appear, and each one plays differently.
2. The change from one season to the next is part of the gameplay.
3. Art or audio created by the team during the event.
4. Accessibility options such as remappable controls, colour-blind friendly visuals, or adjustable difficulty.
5. A short tutorial or first level that teaches the game without text instructions.

WHAT A WINNING SOLUTION LOOKS LIKE

1. A judge can pick up the game and understand the goal within the first minute.
2. The theme is clear from playing the game, without the team explaining it.
3. The seasons affect play in ways such as:
    a. Different rules, hazards, or resources in each season.
    b. Choices made in one season that carry into the next.
    c. A cycle the player has to plan around.
    d. Movement, speed, or visibility that changes with the weather.
4. The game runs from start to finish without crashing.
5. The art and audio follow one style.
6. The game has one idea that is its own and is carried through.
7. The scope is small and finished, and judges want to keep playing.

DELIVERABLES

1. A playable build, demonstrated live and available for judges to play.
2. A pitch of up to 5 minutes, followed by 3 minutes of judge questions.
3. A link to the code or project repository.
4. A list of any third-party assets, tools, or libraries used, with credit.
5. Submission by Friday, October 16 at 12:00 PM.

JUDGING RUBRIC (100 POINTS TOTAL)

Category	Points	Criteria
Theme	**25**	Four Seasons drives the gameplay or story and is not only a backdrop.
Gameplay & Fun	**30**	Playable loop, clear goal, judges want to keep playing.
Art & Audio	**20**	Consistent style that supports the theme.
Playable Build	**15**	Runs start to finish on site without the team stepping in.
Originality	**10**	A new mechanic or idea.

TRACKS

No track is mandatory. Teams may enter the Game Jam Track alone or together with other tracks. A team with one project in several tracks presents once and is scored separately on each track it entered. A game built for the Canadian Bank Note crash game challenge can also enter this track if the seasons change how the game plays.

★ Game Jam Award, $500 CAD Prize

The team that best addresses the Four Seasons theme, as evaluated against the Game Jam rubric, will receive a **$500 CAD cash prize**. This award is judged independently of the main ThunderHacks rubric and will be presented at the closing ceremony.

Algoma University, Faculty of Computer Science and Technology, ThunderHacks 2026